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1 Entrance of the Topkapi palace, Istanbul

2 Istanbul Bosphorus Bridge at night

3 The Basilica Cistern, built in the 6th century

4 The decadent *baklava*, made of layer upon layer of flaky pastry, and filled with nuts and soaked in syrup

5 The Turkish tea, or *Çay*, appears everywhere, accompanying every conversation

the history of Turkish coffee dates to the 16th century and the reign of the Ottoman Sultan Suleiman the Magnificent. Legend says that an Ottoman governor who was posted in Yemen became fond of coffee and introduced it to the palace's cuisine with the first coffee house opening in Istanbul in 1554. During the 1683 Siege of Vienna, Ottoman troops abandoned coffee sacks after failing to capture the city, thus introducing coffee to Europe.

And then there is the *baklava*. Layer upon layer of flaky pastry, filled with nuts and soaked in syrup, satisfying sweet cravings. A kitchen register from Topkapi Palace in 1474 reveals that *baklava* with 41 layers was made daily during Ramzan and demand was so high the team of *baklavacı* couldn't keep up!

But what impresses me most about Istanbul is the city's energy. "The phrase the city that never sleeps was coined for New York but it is true for Istanbul," says Bulut Okçu, my tour guide. Throughout the day, thousands of people fill the streets, markets, and waterfronts. Even the city's famous cats seem constantly occupied, happily posing for tourists!

Yet the city becomes no less lively after dark. Restaurants and cafés remain packed late into the evening. You can go dancing in Taksim Square till the wee hours of the morning, and traffic jams in the middle of the night are common.

As I bid *elveda* (goodbye) to Istanbul, I realise that the greatest attraction is not any single monument. It is the city itself, where the past remains woven into everyday life. **BT**